

Another DHS sting for New Orleans

Agency says it’s hunting for criminals amid outcry from many residents

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE AND ROBERT KLEMKO

NEW ORLEANS — The Department of Homeland Security announced the start of a new immigration enforcement operation in New Orleans on Wednesday, the latest in a series of sweeps that have resulted in thousands of arrests, legal challenges and protests.

DHS said it was launching “Operation Catahoula Crunch” to target “criminal illegal aliens roaming free thanks to sanctuary policies that force local authorities to ignore U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) arrest detainees.”

The announcement included a list and photos of 10 undocumented immigrants — from Honduras, El Salvador, Guatemala, Jordan and Vietnam — who the agency said had been arrested for a variety of crimes in New Orleans and later released.

“The men and women of DHS law enforcement have landed in The Big Easy,” Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem wrote on social media. “Operation Catahoula Crunch will remove the worst of the worst from New Orleans, Louisiana, after the city’s sanctuary politicians have ignored the rule of law.”

Immigration enforcement escalations in Los Angeles, Chicago, SEE DHS ON A8

Ruling: Judge limits warrantless immigration arrests in D.C. B13



ADAM GRAY/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Gregory Bovino, center, U.S. Customs and Border Patrol commander, gathers with agents Wednesday in Metairie, Louisiana.

How Palantir shifted course amid ICE’s deportation efforts

BY EVA DOU

For years, Alex Karp, Palantir’s CEO, had declared the data management company to be “involved in supporting progressive values,” saying he has repeatedly “walked away” from contracts that targeted minorities or that he found otherwise unethical. Even as Palantir took on extensive data management contracts for the federal government, the company said it was not willing to allow its powerful tools to broadly track immigrants across America.

That commitment no longer holds. Palantir’s software is helping

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement track undocumented immigrants and deport them faster, according to federal procurement filings and interviews with people who have knowledge of the project and who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive details. The software, Immigration OS, plays a key role in supporting the administration’s mass deportation campaign, which President Donald Trump has stepped up in recent days with such measures as pausing immigration applications from nationals of 19 countries.

Karp, formerly an outspoken

Democrat who a decade ago said that he respected “nothing” about Trump and that a deportation drive made “no sense,” has staunchly defended the president’s immigration policies in his second term. Declaring Palantir to be “completely anti-woke,” he has repeatedly praised Trump’s ongoing crackdown on immigrants, thrusting the company into one of the country’s most contentious issues.

That shift in political alliances in no way signals a change in his core beliefs, Karp said in a statement to The Washington Post, portraying his commitment to controlling immigration as of a

piece with his long-standing devotion to social justice.

“For over two decades, I have implored our political elite to take seriously the truly progressive position on immigration: one of extreme skepticism. To no avail,” Karp said. “Unfettered immigration in Europe, where I lived for well over a decade, has been a disaster — depressing wages for the working class and resulting in mass social dislocation. I remain an economic progressive, isolated among self-proclaimed progressives that are anything but.”

The changes at Palantir have SEE PALANTIR ON A9

In GOP, vexation grows at Hegseth

KEY PANELS PURSUE ROBUST OVERSIGHT

Pentagon faces questions over civilian boat strikes

BY NOAH ROBERTSON

In a classified briefing for lawmakers scrutinizing the Trump administration’s killing of suspected drug smugglers around Latin America, top Republicans in the room appeared frustrated.

The Pentagon, facing questions about its legal basis for attacking civilian vessels, sent no lawyers to the meeting — a move multiple lawmakers in the room considered inexplicable. The Defense Department officials who did attend, those people said, were unable to explain the mission’s strategy and scope — even as President Donald Trump openly mused about expanding the campaign to include land targets inside Venezuela.

Rep. Mike D. Rogers (Alabama), the House Armed Services Committee’s GOP chairman, condemned the secrecy, saying Congress had gotten more information from the Pentagon during the Biden administration, according to two people in the room. They spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe a private encounter.

A spokesperson for Rogers said it would be “inappropriate to share details from classified discussions” and that they wouldn’t

SEE HEGSETH ON A6

Human rights: Family of slain Colombian man files complaint. A7

Start-ups want to move fast and block the sun

Private efforts to combat warming with technology raise serious concerns

BY NICOLÁS RIVERO

For as little as \$1, you can dim the sun — just a tiny bit — to save the world from climate change.

At least, that’s the promise sold by a California start-up called Make Sunsets. Your dollar will pay for founder Luke Iseman to drive a Winnebago RV into the hills half an hour outside Saratoga, California, to release a balloon loaded with sulfur dioxide, an air pollutant normally speewed by volcanic eruptions. He and his 1,000 paying customers hope the balloon will burst in the stratosphere, releasing particles that will block sunlight and cool the planet.

Iseman’s sun-blocking activities — which aren’t officially approved by any government on Earth, but aren’t illegal under California law — are an example of a controversial tactic called “solar geoengineering.” It has been the subject of many science fiction stories and conspiracy theories and at least one U.S. spy report warning that it could spark real-world wars.

And now it’s becoming a private industry. Make Sunsets has raised more than \$1 million from investors and sold more than \$100,000 worth of “cooling credits” to customers this year. A bet-

ter-funded competitor, Stardust, has raised \$75 million to develop a more sophisticated geoengineering method it says will be ready to launch by the end of the decade — although its founders vow they won’t deploy their technology unless a government hires them to do so.

The companies have sparked debate about the role private firms should play in tinkering with the global climate. Proponents say start-ups can develop a potentially world-changing technology faster than plodding university scientists; in recent years, academics studying geoengineering have tried to do basic outdoor equipment tests in Sweden and California only to face pushback and cancel their plans.

“They stop. They give up,” said Maex Ament, a venture capitalist and Stardust investor. “If I’m an entrepreneur at heart, no, there is no ‘I’ll give up. Next topic.’ I’ll solve this problem, without compromising safety. There’s a different mindset.”

Opponents say profit-seeking companies have no business developing a technology designed to affect everyone on Earth, which may have unintended consequences for global weather patterns and could kill people by raising air pollution and cancer rates.

“I do not trust the private sector to make good decisions for people,” said Shuchi Talati, founder of the nonprofit Alliance for Just Deliberation on Solar

SEE ENGINEERING ON A10



FERNANDO LLANO/AP

Workers in Zamora, Mexico, shepherd cattle in July at a ranch that exports livestock to the U.S.

Parasite ravages cattle trade from Mexico

A U.S. blockade due to New World screwworm disrupts domestic feedlots

BY KARIN BRULLIARD

Juan Manuel Fleischer’s ancestors ranches on the borderlands before the United States existed, and the Arizona resident’s business importing Mexican cattle across the modern-day frontier has survived decades of immigration politics and the construction of a towering steel wall.

But that work has collapsed over the past year as an insidious threat shakes U.S.-Mexico rela-

tions and the American beef industry: the New World screwworm, a flesh-eating parasite that has resurged south of the border 60 years after it was mostly eradicated in U.S. livestock.

Around 1.2 million young Mexican cattle cross each year through a half-dozen entry ports to bulk up in American pastures or feedyards. But the gates have been shut to livestock for most of the past year, since a cow in southern Mexico tested positive

in November 2024 for New World screwworm — maggots that burrow into warm-blooded animals, creating foul-smelling wounds and sometimes fatal weight loss. Mexican cattle imports have plunged to about 230,000 in 2025 as additional cases have emerged farther north, including one in September only 70 miles south of the border.

“We’re hurting,” Fleischer said. “We’re basically going broke.”

SEE SCREWORM ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Trump to pardon Democrat The president said he will end the prosecution of Rep. Henry Cuellar of Texas, a right-leaning lawmaker charged with bribery and other crimes. A4

Undoing Biden-era rules Trump said his administration will roll back fuel efficiency standards for cars and trucks. A14

THE NATION A dozen former FDA commissioners condemned a plan to tighten vaccine approvals. A3
A doctor received 30 months in prison in Matthew Perry’s death from ketamine. A10

THE WORLD U.S. talks in Moscow with Vladimir Putin have yielded little progress or compromise. A11
Sites across England linked to Andrew are downplaying ties to the disgraced ex-prince. A12

THE ECONOMY Amazon is exploring cutting ties with the U.S. Postal Service and launching its own rural delivery network, which may wreak havoc on the agency’s viability. A13

LOCAL LIVING Check out 46 gifts we’re giving (and wishing for) this season.

STYLE Meghan, Duchess of Sussex, is out with a new televised holiday special. Can this be how she saw her future? B1

SPORTS College football’s pre-season rankings have become even more of a fool’s errand in the age of NIL and transfers. B7

THE REGION President Trump vowed to “rebuild” Dulles International Airport, where a modernization effort has been underway since 2023. B13
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